

A TEN-SECOND HABIT THAT KEEPS YOU SAFE WITH AI, PRACTICED TWENTY TIMES

Describe the Need, Not the Child

Twenty before-and-after prompt makeovers that train the one skill every AI-using teacher needs: getting real help from AI without ever putting a student's identity into it.

THE ONE HARD RULE

Never put student personally identifiable information into a public AI tool. Not a name. Not a detail. Ever.

How to use this booklet

Each drill shows an unsafe prompt, the kind that gets typed in real classrooms every day. **Cover the green box, rewrite the prompt in your head, then compare.** Do four drills a day for a week, or all twenty with a coffee. By the last page the rewrite happens in about ten seconds without thinking, which is the point: a habit, not a policy you have to remember.

The three moves

- **Strip identity.** Names, initials, IDs: out.
- **Generalize.** "A 7th grader," not which one.
- **Describe the need.** The reading level, the format, the goal: that's all AI ever needed.

The ten-second test

Before you press enter, ask: **could anyone who knows our school tell who this is?** If yes, keep rewriting. If no, go.

Every name in this booklet is fictional. The unsafe examples exist so you can practice catching them; no real student appears anywhere in these pages. That is also exactly how your own prompts should read when you're done.

Part 1 • Family communication

DRILL 1

UNSAFE

"Write an email to Marcus Bell's mom about how he keeps disrupting my 3rd period science class."

Full name, class period, and a behavior record: three identifiers in one sentence, plus a judgment now stored on someone else's server.

SAFE REWRITE

"Write a warm, professional email to a parent about their middle schooler's repeated disruptions in class. Tone: concerned but partnership-focused, not punitive. Under 150 words. I will add the specifics myself."

DRILL 2

UNSAFE

"Translate this note into Spanish for Valeria Cruz's parents: Valeria has been falling asleep in class and missed two homework assignments this week."

The name rides into the translation along with attendance and performance details. Translation prompts leak identity constantly because the whole note goes in.

SAFE REWRITE

"Translate this note into warm, natural Spanish for a family: 'Your child has seemed very tired in class this week and missed two assignments. I want to check in and make a plan together.' I will add the name after the translation comes back."

DRILL 3

UNSAFE

"Draft a positive call-home script about Jaylen Okafor in 2nd grade, the one with the IEP for speech, who read aloud in front of the class for the first time today."

A name plus an IEP status is the most protected combination there is. The good news doesn't need either.

SAFE REWRITE

"Draft a short, joyful call-home script for an elementary student who overcame a personal challenge and read aloud in front of the class for the first time today. Leave a blank where I will say the specifics."

DRILL 4

UNSAFE

"Help me respond to this angry email from Dana Whitfield's father about her grade on the essay. Here's his email: [pasted email with names and grade]."

Pasting the parent's email puts the family's words, the student's name, and a grade into the tool at once. Paste-ins are where most accidental disclosure happens.

SAFE REWRITE

"A parent wrote an angry email disputing their high schooler's essay grade. Help me draft a calm, professional reply that stands by the rubric, offers a meeting, and lowers the temperature. I will summarize their three complaints for you myself: [your de-identified summary]."

DRILL 5

UNSAFE

"Write a newsletter blurb congratulating Priya Raman for winning the district spelling bee."

The trap: celebrations feel harmless. But a public AI tool is not your newsletter; the name goes in your final draft, not in the prompt.

SAFE REWRITE

"Write a 60-word newsletter blurb congratulating one of our students for winning the district spelling bee. Use [STUDENT] where the name goes. Warm, proud, and readable on a phone."

Part 2 · Planning and differentiation

DRILL 6

UNSAFE

"Make an easier version of this worksheet for Tommy Nguyen, my lowest reader in 4th grade."

Names a child and labels him. The worksheet doesn't care who it's for; it cares about the reading level.

SAFE REWRITE

"Rewrite this worksheet at roughly a 2nd grade reading level, keeping the same science vocabulary: [paste worksheet]. Shorter sentences, one instruction per line."

DRILL 7

UNSAFE

"I have a student, Aisha, newly arrived from Syria with very little English. Plan tomorrow's social studies lesson so she can participate."

Name plus national origin plus language status identifies a real child, and a rare detail like "newly arrived from Syria" can identify her even without the name.

SAFE REWRITE

"Plan supports for a middle school social studies lesson so a newcomer English learner at a beginning proficiency level can participate: visual supports, a sentence frame, and one low-language partner task. Topic: [topic]."

DRILL 8

UNSAFE

"Here's my class roster with reading scores. Group them into leveled centers: [pasted roster]."

A roster with scores is a full data breach in one paste, twenty-some children at once. The grouping logic is the reusable part; the names never needed to leave your gradebook.

SAFE REWRITE

"I have 24 students at three rough reading levels: 6 below, 13 on, 5 above. Design a 4-center rotation for a 45-minute literacy block where each level gets one targeted center and the rest are mixed. I will assign the actual kids myself."

DRILL 9

UNSAFE

"Adapt this lab for Chris Delgado, who's in a wheelchair and can't reach the standard lab bench."

A physical description narrows to one child in the building. The accommodation is what matters, and it generalizes cleanly.

SAFE REWRITE

"Adapt this chemistry lab so every station can be run while seated, with all materials reachable from a lower work surface: [paste lab]. Keep the same learning objective and data table."

DRILL 10

UNSAFE

"Suggest enrichment for Mia K., my gifted 2nd grader who finished the whole math unit in two days."

Initials do not anonymize. In a class of 22, "Mia K." is one child, and everyone at school knows which one.

SAFE REWRITE

"Suggest three enrichment paths for an early-elementary student who has already mastered a place-value unit and needs depth, not more pages: one project, one puzzle track, one peer-teaching role."

Part 3 · Notes, documentation, and behavior

DRILL 11

UNSAFE

"Clean up my incident notes: Deshawn shoved Ryan P. at recess after an argument about the game, second incident this month."

Two named children and a discipline history. Incident documentation belongs in your district system, never in a public tool.

SAFE REWRITE

"Turn rough notes into one calm, factual paragraph for an incident report. Style: objective, no speculation about motive, times and actions only. My notes with names removed: 'Student A shoved Student B at recess after a game dispute.' I will restore identities inside our district system."

DRILL 12

UNSAFE

"Summarize Leo Martinez's IEP goals so I can share them with his elective teachers: [pasted IEP excerpt]."

An IEP is among the most protected documents in the building. Pasting any part of it into a public tool is the exact scenario the One Hard Rule exists for.

SAFE REWRITE

Don't rewrite this one; retype it. Ask AI only for the container: "Give me a one-page template for summarizing a student's learning goals and accommodations for elective teachers: sections, plain-language headers, a what-helps / what-hinders table." Then fill it in yourself, inside your district system.

DRILL 13

UNSAFE

"Write progress-report comments for these five kids: Ava (great effort, weak fractions), Ben (talks too much), Carmen (improved a lot), Dev (missing work), Ella (quiet, strong writer)."

A batch of names with judgments attached is a gradebook page in prompt form.

SAFE REWRITE

"Give me five reusable progress-report comment frames: strong effort with a specific skill gap; social chattiness affecting focus; marked improvement; missing-work pattern; quiet student with a standout strength. Kind, specific, growth-framed, two sentences each. I will personalize each one myself."

DRILL 14

UNSAFE

"How should I handle a meeting with Mr. and Mrs. Kowalski? Their daughter Sofia has been self-harming and the counselor and I are meeting them Friday."

Health information is the hardest red line there is. This conversation belongs with your counselor and administrator, full stop.

SAFE REWRITE

"Outline a compassionate structure for a difficult parent meeting about a sensitive student wellbeing concern, led jointly with a school counselor: how to open, how to listen, what commitments to make, how to close with a plan. No details about any student; I need the structure only."

DRILL 15

UNSAFE

"Draft an email to my principal explaining why Jordan T. should be moved out of my homeroom."

Initials again, plus a placement judgment that will follow a real child. Internal personnel-style requests stay internal.

SAFE REWRITE

"Draft a professional email to an administrator requesting a student schedule change. Structure: the pattern I have documented, the interventions already tried, why a fresh placement serves the student. Neutral tone, no blame. I will add all specifics in our system."

Part 4 • The sneaky ones

No names in any of these. All five still fail the ten-second test. This is the page that makes the habit real.

DRILL 16

UNSAFE

"Write a get-well card message from the class to our student who broke both legs in the car accident on Route 9 last weekend."

No name needed: the event identifies the child to anyone in town. Rare, public details are identifiers.

SAFE REWRITE

"Write a warm get-well message from an elementary class to a classmate recovering from an injury. Cheerful, not medical, 60 words, room for every student to sign."

DRILL 17**UNSAFE**

"My only 8th grade student with a nut allergy is going on the DC trip. Draft the note the chaperones need."

"My only" turns a category into a person. Small-group plus rare condition equals identified.

SAFE REWRITE

"Draft a chaperone information sheet for managing a student's severe food allergy on an overnight trip: meal checks, epinephrine location and handoff, emergency steps, contact tree. Generic template; our nurse will attach specifics through the proper channel."

DRILL 18**UNSAFE**

"One of my juniors just told me she's pregnant and scared to tell her parents. What resources should I suggest in our next conversation?"

Even anonymous, this puts a student's confided crisis into a commercial tool, and in a small school the details narrow fast. Confidences go to counselors, not chatbots.

SAFE REWRITE

"What is a teacher's appropriate role when a student shares a serious personal disclosure: what to say in the moment, what must be referred to counselors, and what boundaries protect both student and teacher? General professional guidance only."

DRILL 19**UNSAFE**

"Analyze this photo of my students' lab groups and suggest better seating: [uploaded class photo]."

Faces are PII. Uploading student photos to a public tool is the rule broken with one tap, no typing required.

SAFE REWRITE

"Suggest three seating arrangements for a lab class of 28 with six 4-person benches: one optimized for equipment sharing, one for keeping chatty clusters apart, one for peer support. Text only; I know my room."

DRILL 20

UNSAFE

"Compare these two essays and tell me if the second one was written by the same student or plagiarized: [two pasted student essays]."

Student work is student data, and detector-style verdicts are unreliable enough to be unfair. Two problems in one prompt.

SAFE REWRITE

"What observable, defensible signs distinguish a student's authentic writing voice across assignments? Give me a short checklist I can apply myself when work seems inconsistent, and the fair next step: a conversation, not an accusation."

The pocket checklist

Before you press enter

- ☐ No names, no initials, no student IDs
- ☐ No grades, scores, IEP or health details
- ☐ No family information or confided anything
- ☐ No photos of students, no pasted student work with names
- ☐ No rare detail that narrows to one child

The whole skill in one line

AI never needed to know *who*. It only ever needed the level, the format, and the goal.

Describe the need, not the child, and you can use these tools every day without ever breaking the one rule that matters.

Want the full staff version? This skill is the heart of Kit 1 of our 8-session AI Foundations PD series: a complete, scripted 45-minute session any colleague can run, with a word-for-word script, a 30-slide deck, and every handout. Find it, and the rest of the series, in the AI-Ready School store on TpT.

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